

Word family: **proper / properly / improper / improperly / propriety**

Base word: proper

Related forms: properly, improper, improperly, propriety

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / adverb-related form (相關副詞)

Your sentence:

> “The lesson he taught me was the value of patience and doing things **properly**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **properly** means **in the correct, careful, and appropriate way, rather than rushing or doing something carelessly**.

繁體中文： **以正確、妥當、仔細而合適的方式去做；把事情做好做妥**

中文翻譯：

> “...the value of patience and doing things **properly**.”

「.....耐性，以及把事情**正確、妥善地做好**的價值。」

The base adjective is:

> **proper = correct, suitable, or done according to the right standard**

1. **proper = correct / appropriate (做法 / 方式) — 正確的；恰當的；妥當的**

This is the core meaning behind your passage.

Meaning: Correct or suitable for a particular situation, purpose, standard, or set of rules.

Practice 1 — Original family use

> “He taught me the importance of doing things **properly**.”

「他教會我把事情**正確妥善地做好**的重要性。」

Practice 2

> “You need the **proper** tools for the job.”

「你需要合適而**正確的**工具來完成這項工作。」

Practice 3

> “There is a **proper** way to handle this equipment.”

「這套設備有一套**正確 / 恰當**的操作方法。」

proper = 符合要求、標準、規則或實際需要的；正確妥當的

Common:

- * proper procedure
- * proper method
- * proper care
- * proper equipment
- * proper way

2. **proper** = socially acceptable / behaving correctly (禮儀 / 規矩) — 得體的；合乎禮儀的

Proper can refer specifically to behaviour regarded as polite, respectable, or socially appropriate.

Practice 4

> “He was taught how to behave in a **proper** manner.”

「他被教導如何以**得體 / 合乎禮儀**的方式行事。」

Practice 5

> “She felt that jeans were not **proper** for such a formal occasion.”

「她覺得牛仔褲不適合如此正式的場合，不夠**得體**。」

proper = 符合社會禮儀、規矩或場合要求的

This develops from the broader **appropriate/correct** sense.

For strict core counting, I would merge it with Meaning 1 while keeping the social-behaviour branch explicit.

3. **proper** = real / complete / of the expected kind (真正的 / 像樣的) — 真正的；完整的；像

樣的**

In British English especially, **proper** can emphasize that something is a genuine, complete, or satisfactory example of its kind.

Practice 6

> “We haven’t had a **proper** meal all day.”

「我們整天都沒有吃過一頓**像樣 / 真正完整的**飯。」

Practice 7

> “I need a **proper** rest after this week.”

「過完這星期後，我需要真正**好好休息一下**。」

proper = 真正符合某類事物應有的完整程度、品質或標準的

Here, **proper meal** does not merely mean “correct meal.” It means:

> **a real, substantial, satisfactory meal**

This is distinct enough to keep separately for learners.

4. **proper = specific/main thing itself (本身 / 正式) — 真正的；本身的；正式的**

Proper can distinguish the main or actual thing from surrounding areas, preliminary stages, or related material.

Practice 8

> “The ceremony began before the meeting **proper**.”

「正式會議開始之前先舉行了儀式。」

Practice 9

> “They live outside the city **proper**.”

「他們住在城市**本身的正式範圍**以外。」

noun + proper = 某事物本身的主要、正式或嚴格意義上的部分

Common:

- * the city proper
- * the meeting proper
- * the event proper

This is an established formal construction.

5. **proper = belonging specifically/exclusively to something (專屬) — 特有的 ; 本身所屬的**

In more formal English, **proper** can mean belonging specifically to the thing being discussed.

Practice 10

> “The responsibilities **proper** to the role are clearly defined.”

「這個角色**本身特有 / 應有的**責任已有清楚界定。」

Practice 11

> “These functions are **proper** to the department.”

「這些職能是該部門**本身所屬 / 專有的**。」

proper to something = 特別屬於某人、某物或某職能的

This is valid modern English but more formal and lower-frequency.

For a learner database, I would include it as a secondary branch rather than a top-priority everyday meaning.

6. **proper = own / individual (語法術語) — 專有的**

This appears prominently in **proper noun / proper name**.

Practice 12

> “‘Hong Kong’ is a **proper noun**.”

「Hong Kong 是一個**專有名詞**。」

Practice 13

> “A **proper name** identifies a particular person or place.”

「**專有名稱**指某一特定人物或地方的名稱。」

Here:

proper = referring to one particular individual entity rather than a general class

This is a specialized grammatical use.

I would treat **proper noun/name** as an important domain-specific extension, not as a separate everyday lexical core.

Related form: **properly**

Properly is the exact form in your sentence.

properly = correctly / appropriately (正確地 ; 妥善地)

Practice 14

> “The machine is not working **properly**.”

「這部機器沒有**正常 / 正確地**運作。」

Practice 15

> “Make sure the door is closed **properly**.”

「確保門已經**妥善地**關好。」

properly = 以正確、合適、完整或應有的方式

properly = thoroughly / genuinely (真正地 ; 充分地)

Practice 16

> “I haven’t **properly** eaten all day.”

「我整天都沒有**好好地 / 真正地**吃過東西。」

Practice 17

> “We never **properly** discussed the issue.”

「我們從來沒有**認真完整地**討論過這個問題。」

This develops from:

> **proper = complete/genuine**

rather than only “correct.”

Related form: **improper**

Improper means not correct, suitable, or socially acceptable.

Practice 18

> “The machine failed because of **improper** use.”

「機器因**使用不當**而故障。」

Practice 19

> “His behaviour was considered **improper**.”

「他的行為被認為**不得體 / 不恰當**。」

improper = 不符合正確方式、規則、標準或社會禮儀的

Related form: **propriety**

Propriety is a formal noun referring to correct, appropriate, or socially acceptable behaviour.

Practice 20

> “She questioned the **propriety** of his behaviour.”

「她質疑他的行為是否**得體 / 合乎規範**。」

Practice 21

> “They behaved with complete **propriety**.”

「他們的行為完全**合乎禮節 / 得體**。」

propriety = 行為符合禮儀、規矩、道德或社會規範的狀態

This is useful formal vocabulary but lower-frequency than **proper/properly**.

Important distinction: **proper vs correct**

correct

focuses on:

> being factually or technically right

proper

can mean:

- * correct
- * suitable
- * appropriate
- * socially acceptable
- * complete/genuine

For example:

> the correct answer

= 正確答案

> proper behaviour

= 得體行為

So **proper** is broader than **correct**.

Important distinction: **proper vs appropriate**

appropriate

means suitable for the particular situation.

proper

can mean suitable, but can also suggest an established standard of how something **should** be done.

> appropriate clothing

= 適合場合的衣服

> proper clothing

can suggest clothing considered correct or expected by convention.

Important distinction: **proper vs suitable**

suitable

means fit for a particular purpose.

proper

often adds the idea of:

- * correctness
- * standard
- * accepted procedure

> suitable tool

= 工具適合用途

> proper tool

= 正確 / 應該使用的工具

Important distinction: **proper vs real**

In expressions such as:

> a proper meal

proper can mean something close to **real**, but with an added idea of adequacy or completeness.

> a real meal

= 真正的飯餐

> a proper meal

= 一頓完整、像樣、符合期待的飯餐

Important distinction: **proper** vs **properly**

proper

adjective:

> “Use the proper method.”

「使用正確的方法。」

properly

adverb:

> “Do it properly.”

「把它正確妥善地做好。」

This is the exact grammatical contrast in your passage.

Useful construction: **proper noun** — 專有名詞

Practice 22

> “Names of cities are usually **proper nouns**.”

「城市名稱通常是**專有名詞**。」

This is a domain-specific compound rather than a new general everyday meaning.

Useful construction: **X proper — X 本身 / 正式部分**

Practice 23

> “The discussion began before the lecture **proper**.”

「討論在**正式講座本身**開始之前就開始了。」

Practice 24

> “The village lies outside the town **proper**.”

「這條村位於城鎮**正式範圍本身**之外。」

This construction deserves explicit learner attention because **proper** comes **after** the noun.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

- * **proper**
- * **properly**
- * **improper**
- * **improperly**
- * **propriety**

Useful constructions include:

- * proper way
- * proper procedure
- * proper behaviour
- * proper meal
- * proper rest
- * proper noun
- * city proper
- * meeting proper
- * do something properly

The Golden Manual says adjective contrasts, grammatical constructions, and useful family forms should be checked, while meanings should be split only where the learner needs a genuinely different mental concept.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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proper — correct/appropriate	符合要求、標準、規則或實際需要的；正確、恰當、妥當的
proper — socially acceptable	符合禮儀、規矩或場合要求的；得體的；屬於 appropriate 義
proper — genuine/complete	真正符合某類事物應有品質、完整程度或標準的；像樣的 / 真正的
noun + proper	指某事物本身的主要、正式或嚴格意義上的部分
proper to something	特別屬於某人、事物、角色或功能的；正式用法
proper noun/name	指某一特定人物、地方等的專有名稱；語法專門用法
properly	以正確、合適、完整或應有的方式
improper	不符合正確方式、標準、規則或禮儀的
propriety	行為符合禮儀、規矩或社會規範的狀態；正式

For your original sentence

> “...the value of patience and doing things ****properly****.”

The exact meaning is:

****properly = 以正確、仔細、妥善而符合應有標準的方式****

The surrounding passage makes this especially clear: the grandfather teaches the speaker ****not to rush, skip steps, or cut corners****.

So:

> ****doing things properly****

= ****把事情按正確步驟、仔細而妥善地做好****

For your database, I would count ****3 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****proper****:

1. ****correct / appropriate / according to the right standard****
2. ****genuine, complete, or satisfactory of its kind — a proper meal/rest****
3. ****the thing itself in its strict/main sense — city proper / meeting proper****

I would merge socially ****proper behaviour**** into #1, keep ****proper noun**** and ****proper to**** as domain/formal extensions, and treat ****properly, improper, propriety**** as family extensions rather than inflate the base-word count.